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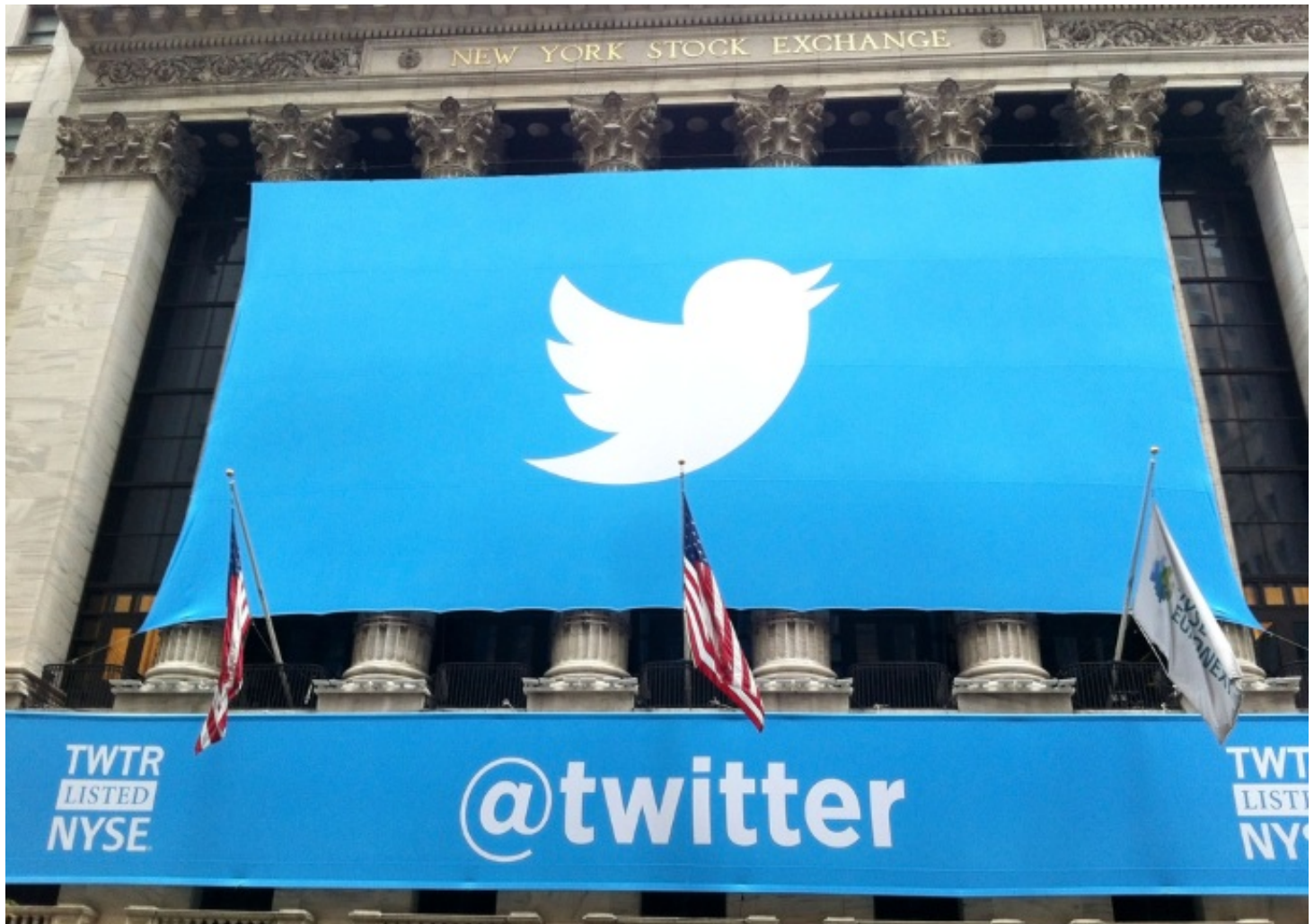
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Twitter C.E.O. Dick Costolo Stepping Down



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By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

June 17, 2015

Dick Costolo, Twitter's chief executive, announced on Thursday that he will be stepping down amid criticism concerning the platform's stagnant growth. Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey is expected to take over as interim chief executive during the search for a permanent successor.

"Investors took the news well after the announcement on Thursday, and the stock surged by up to 7% in after-hours trading. In pre-market trading on Friday, Twitter's stock rose by as much as 5%," [reports](#) Akin Oyedele at Business Insider.

Costolo led Twitter for the past five years, however sluggish growth and a decrease in monthly active users mixed with repeated failed attempts at making the platform more appealing has taken its toll on the exiting chief executive.

Costolo addressed his reasoning for stepping down before finding a replacement in a [prepared statement](#):

"We're making this public announcement prior to naming a permanent CEO and in fact at the very start of the

official search because we want to be open about our search for Twitter's next long term leader. We also want to attract the best possible candidates and not distract the organization with the inevitable speculation and rumors that would obviously occur if we were to attempt to conduct a CEO search privately."



Moving Forward

"There is never, ever the right time to begin a transition like this," Costolo said during a call to investors. And despite investors shrugging off the shifting leadership at Twitter, Morgan Stanley analysts issue a [harsh diagnosis](#) on the platform's future:

"The bottom line is that, as Jack Dorsey stated, TWTR has unmet potential. And the surprise timing of this announcement, combined with the "steady-as-she-goes" tone of the executives on the conference call, indicate to us that TWTR will continue to underperform until it can either a) significantly improve its execution against its current strategy, or b) institute a new vision."

Wells Fargo analysts note the decision to keep Costolo on the board may signal a confidence in future plans for Twitter. "By reaffirming [Twitter's] strategy and keeping Costolo on the board, could Twitter's board be sending a signal that no changes are likely?"

And would the return of Twitter co-founder Jack Dorsey as interim chief executive signal triage or return to

form for the messaging platform? When Business Insider asked if he intends to stay permanently as full-time chief executive, Dorsey responded flatly: "I'm not focused on that question at all," Dorsey [said](#). "I'm focused on making sure we continue our momentum and to amplify what we're doing."

Takeaway

The future remains unclear for Twitter. Analysts are quick to note the larger issue beyond rearranging leadership at one of the most ubiquitous social media sites: "We believe the key question remains whether TWTR will make necessary changes to lure back the roughly 700MM+ users we believe use the service infrequently, or have left altogether," the analysts [wrote](#).

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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